UNIT 1 ELECTROSTATICS

Electricity is really just organized lightning
– George Carlin

Learning Objectives

In this unit, student is exposed to

- Historical background of electricity and magnetism
- The role of electrostatic force in day – to-day life
- Coulomb's law and superposition principle
- The concept of electric field
- Calculation of electric field for various charge configurations
- Electrostatic potential and electrostatic potential energy
- Electric dipole and dipole moment
- Electric field and electrostatic potential for a dipole
- Electric flux
- Gauss law and its various applications
- Electrostatic properties of conductors and dielectrics
- Polarisation
- Capacitors in series and parallel combinations
- Effect of a dielectric in a capacitor
- Distribution of charges in conductors, corona discharge
- Working of a Van de Graaff generator

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1.1 INTRODUCTION

Electromagnetism is one of the most important branches of physics. The technological developments of the modern 21st century are primarily due to our understanding of electromagnetism. The forces we experience in everyday life are electromagnetic in nature except gravity.

In standard XI, we studied about the gravitational force, tension, friction, normal force etc. Newton treated them to be independent of each other with each force being a separate natural force. But what is the origin of all these forces? It is now understood that except gravity, all forces which we experience in every day life (tension in the string, normal force from the surface, friction etc.) arise from electromagnetic forces within the atoms. Some examples are

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